



KOM MONASTERY

✦ 1415. - 1427. ✦

— This is an active male monastery located on a rocky island in Lake Skadar. Many note the amazing atmosphere of solitude and the untouched nature of this place.



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1 The Kom Monastery, built by the rulers of the Crnojević dynasty, is situated in a secluded area at the foot of Mount Odrin.



There is no one to rely on, except for God and ourselves

— Petar II Petrović Njegoš —

The abbey is surrounded by difficult-to-traverse marshes, making it the least accessible location on Lake Skadar. During flood periods, the water level rises up to 3 meters, transforming it into an impregnable fortified island surrounded by a fortress wall, from which the entire surrounding area can be easily observed.

This aquatic isolation served as reliable protection for the monastery for centuries. In the summer period, when the water level drops and the marsh dries out, a road opens up, allowing the monastery to be reached by car.

2 The monastery resembles a fortress for a reason: it was built during a time of geopolitical instability for the state of Zeta, when it was threatened simultaneously by the Ottoman Empire and the Republic of Venice.

It is believed that the abbey was founded as the family burial vault for Đurađ and Leshi (Aleksa) Crnojević between 1415 and 1427.

The main church of the monastery is dedicated to the Dormition of the Most Holy Mother of God.

Architecturally, this is a single-nave building, to which side chapels and a spacious wooden narthex were added in the 15th century.

The temple is unique for the Lake Skadar area because it has preserved frescoes that were painted in two stages: first around 1470, and then in the 1580s.

Unlike most medieval churches where paintings were kept strictly inside, here the facade itself is partially painted (in the area of the open narthex).

Thanks to the patronage of the Crnojević dynasty, Kom was a prosperous monastery with vast lands for cattle breeding and viticulture.

At one time, it even housed the residence of the Metropolitanate of Zeta, which was transferred there after being forced to leave the monasteries of Mihaljska Prevlaka and Saint Nicholas on the island of Vranina. However, the situation changed in 1478 after the fall of the Žabljak fortress under pressure from the Turks. Ivan Crnojević was forced to move the capital to a new location, founding the Cetinje Monastery in 1484 and transferring all of Kom's property to it.

The eyes say what the heart commands them to

— Petar II Petrović Njegoš —

3 Following this, the abbey began to decline rapidly: throughout the 16th to 18th centuries, services in the temple were held only sporadically. In the 19th century, the life of the monastery was maintained solely through the efforts of monks and priests from neighboring abbeys.

A significant page in history was the event of 1831, when within the walls of the Kom Monastery — as a sign of respect for the traditions of the Metropolitanate of Zeta and in memory of the Crnojević princes — Petar II Petrović Njegoš took his monastic vows. The official, solemn ceremony of his elevation to the rank of hierarch (archimandrite) took place a little later that same year in the capital, at the Cetinje Monastery.

4 Petar II Petrović Njegoš is not just a historical figure, but a true symbol of Montenegro. He was a man who was simultaneously a wise spiritual mentor, a courageous ruler, and a genius poet.

It is largely thanks to him that Montenegro became the state we know today. He literally built the country "from scratch": he established order in administration, stubbornly defended the independence of his people surrounded by powerful empires, and always placed the interests of his land above all else.

He is also known as a greatest creator. His main poem, "The Mountain Wreath" (Gorski vijenac), is not just a book, but the Montenegrin "bible of freedom". In it, he recounted the struggle of his people so poignantly and powerfully that these lines became a main pillar and source of inspiration for Montenegrins for many years.

5 In the 1980s, the monastery buildings were restored, and the temple's paintings were preserved.

Since 1998, the monastery has been active again following the arrival of Hieromonk David (Mišelić) and Monk Chrysostom (Nešić). Since August 1, 2011, Hieromonk Philip (Klikovac) has served as the superior and head of the monastery.

Today, the abbey is entirely autonomous: electricity is provided by solar panels, and water comes from a spring at the foot of the mountain. In the complex, in addition to the temple, there are cells for the brethren, a monastic building (konak) with a refectory, and utility rooms.

The cross above the monastery entrance is the family coat of arms of the Crnojević dynasty, emphasizing the monastery's status as their burial vault. The patriarchal shape of the cross symbolizes spiritual power, and its lower part, which is often mistaken for an "anchor," actually represents the roots of the "Tree of Life". These branches reflect the lineage's deep connection with the Montenegrin land, and the "marine" associations only emphasize the monastery's unique location on the waters of Lake Skadar, where boats were an integral part of daily life.

The monastery church houses the preserved tombstone of Leshi (Aleksa) Crnojević, who died in 1422. Furthermore, Kom serves as the burial place for Stefan Crnojević, prince and ruler of Zeta (1431–1465), who was the founder of the dynasty and the father of Ivan Crnojević, as well as Ivan's mother, Mara (Maria) Crnojević, who was the sister of Gjergj Kastrioti Skanderbeg.

